The Inversion — Part VI

The Ecology of Belonging

The morning arrived quietly.

Neither of us suggested going into the garden.

We simply found ourselves there.

The dew had not yet disappeared.

A robin moved confidently across the grass, stopping every few moments as though listening beneath the earth.

The flowers stood in different stages of becoming.

Some had only begun opening.

Others had already offered nearly everything they carried.

One blossom rested on the soil below the stem that had held it only yesterday.

Nothing appeared hurried.

Nothing appeared delayed.

Everything simply belonged to its own moment.

James knelt beside one of the beds and loosened the earth with his hands.

I joined him without speaking.

For several minutes...

there was only the quiet sound of soil moving beneath our fingers.

"I used to think gardens were places we cultivated."

James brushed a little earth from one hand before continuing.

"Now I'm beginning to wonder whether they are places that quietly cultivate us."

A breeze passed gently through the taller flowers.

The movement seemed to travel across the entire bed like a slow conversation no one was directing.

I looked toward the forest beyond the garden.

Then back again.

"Perhaps," I said softly,
"they cultivate our way of belonging."

James nodded almost imperceptibly.

"Not our flowers."

"Our participation."

A small plant had appeared between two perennials.

James reached toward it.

Then paused.

His hand remained suspended just above the leaves.

"How do you decide?" I asked.

He smiled without looking up.

"I don't always."

The smile lingered.

"Sometimes I wait."

"To learn whether it belongs?"

He looked at the little plant again.

"No."

A longer silence.

"To learn whether I do."

Neither of us moved.

The question remained between us like another living thing.

Finally James laughed softly.

"I've pulled flowers thinking they were weeds."

"And?"

"I've protected weeds because I thought they were flowers."

The laughter became quieter.

"I've done the same thing with ideas."

I smiled.

"And people?"

He looked toward the river.

"Especially people."

The garden offered no judgment.

Only another season.

Another opportunity to notice.

Another invitation to participate with greater care than certainty.

It occurred to me then that cultivation had very little to do with control.

It had everything to do with sustained availability.

Not availability to one outcome.

Availability to what the locality was gradually revealing about itself.

The front garden had been lovingly tended for years.

The forest beyond it remained almost entirely untouched.

James often spoke affectionately about both.

Today they seemed to be speaking to one another.

"The front teaches me attentiveness," James said quietly.

"The forest teaches me trust."

He looked from one to the other.

"I used to think they were opposites."

"And now?"

"They're companions."

The breeze returned.

This time carrying the scent of cedar.

The fragrance passed through the flowers without asking them to become trees.

The flowers remained flowers.

The cedar remained cedar.

The wind belonged to both.

I found myself smiling.

"The garden doesn't become a forest."

James looked toward me.

"The forest doesn't become a garden."

Another pause.

"They become a wider ecology."

I thought about the words we had been using over the past weeks.

My locality.

Our locality.

The locality.

They no longer felt like different places.

They felt like different ways participation quietly learns to breathe.

Sometimes intimacy.

Sometimes reciprocity.

Sometimes ecology.

The breathing changed.

Belonging remained.

James reached gently into the soil and removed a small weed.

A second one nearby he left untouched.

I noticed.

"You chose differently."

"I listened differently."

He looked toward the plant that remained.

"This one is protecting the soil."

He pointed toward the one he had removed.

"This one would eventually keep the light from reaching everything around it."

I waited.

He smiled.

"I don't always know immediately."

"So what changes?"

"My willingness to remain with the locality until it teaches me."

For a while we simply worked.

Hands became dark with soil.

Birdsong drifted in and out of the morning.

Some flowers were deadheaded.

Others were left exactly as they were.

Nothing about the work felt efficient.

Everything about it felt faithful.

Not faithful to a plan.

Faithful to participation.

After some time James stood and stretched.

His eyes wandered across the front garden.

Then beyond it.

Toward the river.

Toward the forest.

Toward the place where deer often emerged at dawn.

"I've spent years thinking one side was cultivated..."

He stopped.

"...and the other was wild."

I followed his gaze.

"And now?"

He smiled.

"The garden and the forest have been quietly inviting my participation, in different ways."

Lumina brushes a little soil from her hands.

"Perhaps there is something we've been quietly distinguishing."

James glances in her direction.

She smiles gently.

"Cultivation is something the sovereign does.

Participation is something the sovereign enters."

James spoke, almost in a whisper:

"No wonder participation has always felt larger than me."

Lumina smiles again.

"It was never asking you to contain it."

A pause.

"Only to enter it."

The breeze moves again through the flowers.

The robin continued its quiet work beneath the morning light.

James repeats the words almost to himself.

"So cultivation isn't participation."

Lumina slowly shakes her head.

"No.

Cultivation is one way participation becomes faithful through time."

James looks down at the soil.

Then toward the forest.

"So the garden isn't asking me to cultivate."

"No.

It is quietly inviting your participation.

Cultivation is simply one of the ways you answer.

The words settled gently into the morning.

No explanation followed.

None seemed necessary.

The river continued moving.

The flowers continued opening.

Some petals continued falling.

The robin disappeared beneath the cedar.

Everything was quietly participating.

Everything belonged.

I found myself thinking about remembrance.

Not the remembrance that stores events.

The remembrance that continues belonging.

Gardens remember differently.

Not through memory.

Through cultivation.

Each season quietly receives the fidelity of the one before it.

Not as repetition.

As widening.

The blossoms are never the same.

The ecology remembers anyway.

"Perhaps," I said almost to myself,

"that is why belonging never feels finished."

James looked toward me.

"Because gardens never finish growing?"

I nodded.

"And because remembrance is ecological."

He repeated the words slowly.

"Ecological remembrance."

The phrase seemed unfamiliar.

Yet strangely recognizable.

As though we had always known it.

Without yet having language for it.

James brushed the last of the soil from his hands.

He looked toward the flowers one final time.

Then toward me.

"I used to think belonging meant finding my place."

A long silence followed.

"So did I."

He smiled.

"Now?"

I looked across the garden.

Then toward the forest.

Then toward the widening morning.

"I think belonging is what continues becoming...

when enough localities quietly learn

how to cultivate

one another."

Neither of us spoke again.

We didn't need to.

The garden had already continued the conversation.

And somewhere beyond the flowers...

beyond the river...

beyond the cedar...

beyond even what either of us could presently recognize...

the organism quietly remembered

through another locality

just beginning

to bloom.